Giuliano Formisano

Department of Political Science, University of Zurich
giuliano.formisano@uzh.ch — https://giulianoformisano.github.io/

Last Update: October 14, 2026

Academic Appointments

- **University of Zurich - Department of Political Science** — Zurich, CH
  Postdoctoral Research Fellow, Digital Technology & Politics — *2025 - Present*

- **University of Oxford - Department of Politics & IR** — Oxford, UK
  Research Associate, AuthLib project — *2023 - 2026*

Education

- **University of Oxford** — Oxford, UK
  Doctor of Philosophy (PhD); Social Data Science — *2021 - 2025*
  Courses: Data Analytics, Machine Learning, Natural Language Processing, Networks, Statistics
  Thesis: Exploring Online Polarisation in the US: A Computational Social Science Approach
  Assessors: Prof Sara Hobolt (LSE), Prof Mohsen Mosleh (Oxford)

  - **Yale University** - Department of Politics — New Haven, USA
    Visiting Scholar; Advisor: Prof Joshua Kalla — *Spring 2024*
    Courses: Applied Machine Learning, Social Network Analysis, Game Theory
  - **Sciences Po, Paris** - Centre for European Studies and Comparative Politics — Paris, FRA
    Visiting Scholar; Advisors: Dr Joost de Moor & Prof Caterina Froio — *Spring 2023*

- **University of Oxford** — Oxford, UK
  Master of Philosophy (MPhil); Comparative Government — *2019 - 2021*

- **University of Exeter** — Exeter, UK
  Bachelor of Arts (BA); Politics and International Relations — *2016 - 2019*

Peer-Reviewed Research

* = Equal contribution.

6. Novelli, C., Argota Sánchez-Vaquerizo, J., Cyr, J., **Formisano, G.**, Dougall, S., Sandri, G., and Floridi, L. (forthcoming) Fake Plastic Voters: When Political Parties Can Use AI-Simulated Focus Groups. *Journal of Political Marketing.*

5. **Formisano, G.**, Froio, C., & Castelli Gattinara, P. (conditionally accepted) Automating Protest Event Analysis: A Transformer-Based Framework for Multilingual Classification of Newspaper Articles. *Political Science Research & Methods.*

4. **Formisano, G.***, Hine, E.*, Juneja, P., Laitila, J., Novelli, C., Chiu, E., Dejanikus, E., Levin, M., Schroder, T., West, A., & Floridi, L., (2026) Editorial Governance Under Pressure: Wikipedia's Revert Dynamics During the 2024 US Election. *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications*, 13, pp. 1-16.

3. **Formisano, G.**, Friedrichs, F., Schaffner, F., & Stoehr, N. (2026) Populism and Governmentalism as Thin-Centered Ideologies: Emotions and Frames on Social Media. *European Journal of Political Research*, 65(2), pp. 607–626.

2. Novelli, C., **Formisano, G.**, Juneja, P., Sandri, G., & Floridi, L. (2024) Artificial Intelligence for the Internal Democracy of Political Parties. *Minds and Machines*, 34(36), pp. 1-26.

1. Friedrichs, J.*, Stoehr, N.*, & **Formisano, G.*** (2022) Fear-Anger Contests: Governmental and Populist Politics of Emotion. *Online Social Networks and Media*, 32, pp. 1-13.

Working papers

* = Equal contribution.

6. **Formisano, G.**, Henry, C., Proma, A.M., Hoes, E., Klüser, J., Donnay, K., & Gilardi, F., Indirect Effects of Content Moderation Errors: A Chatroom Experiment with AI Agents. *Under review.*
5. Errichiello, E.*, & **Formisano, G.***, Speaking Security Without Authority: Digital Capital and Security Influencers. *Revise & Resubmit*
4. **Formisano, G.**, Kosmidis, S., & Theocharis, Y., Measuring Online Polarisation: A Supervised Machine Learning Approach.
3. **Formisano, G.**, Lattmann, J.F., & Friedrichs, J., Communication Feedback Between Politicians and Citizens on Social Media.
2. Clemente, A.*, & **Formisano, G.***, Mind the Bricks: Fairness Beliefs and Local Housing Inequality in the UK.
   - *Winner of the 2025* ***Elinor Ostrom Award*** *by the Italian Political Science Association.*
1. **Formisano, G.**, The Network Dynamics of Online Polarisation in the US.

Selected work in progress

4. Clemente, A., & **Formisano, G.**, How Collective Efficacy Shapes Attitudes Toward Inequality.
   - *Funded by the Inequality Research Fund, University of Zurich.*
3. **Formisano, G.**, Norms and Partisan Boundaries in Political Interactions.
   - *Funded by the IPZ Research Grant, University of Zurich.*
2. **Formisano, G.**, & Valentim, V., Public Responses to Violations of Different Political Norms.
1. Whitefield, S., Kosmidis, S., & **Formisano, G.**, Programmatic and Emotional Appeals of Illiberal Parties.

Conferences, Workshops, and Talks

Conferences

- European Political Science Association/Society (EPSA/S): 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025, 2026
- American Political Science Association (APSA): 2023, 2024, 2025, 2026
- Swiss Political Science Association: 2026
- CompText: 2025, 2026
- PolMeth Europe: 2025

Workshops

- 2026 (past and scheduled): Workshop on Survey Designs & Survey Experiments, University of Zurich; APSA Pre-Conference in Political Communication, Boston; Democracy Under Pressure Workshop, ETH Zurich; Democracy and AI, University College Dublin; AUTHLIB Final Conference, Budapest
- 2025: Polarization Workshop, MIT; Digital Democracy Workshop, University of Zurich; The Future of Social Media Research Workshop, University of Oxford; APSA Pre-Conference in Political Communication, Vancouver; Representation in Divided Democracies Workshop, ETH Zurich; EPSA Pre-Conference in Large Language Models, Madrid; Social and Moral Norms Workshop, University of Oxford
- 2024: Harnessing LLMs in Political Science Workshop, Trinity College, Dublin; Work in Progress Seminar, Data Ethics Center, Yale University; AI and Algorithms in Government Conference, Yale University; Pre-Publication Workshop, SciencesPo, Paris
- 2023: Theory Research Cluster, London School of Economics; Research in Progress Seminar, Department of Politics, University of Oxford; APSA Pre-Conference in Political Economy, Los Angeles
- 2022: DPhil Seminar, Oxford Internet Institute, University of Oxford; DPhil Work in Progress Workshop, Department of Politics, University of Oxford; PhD Work in Progress Seminar, European University Institute; 17th Annual Doctoral Conference/Workshop, Central European University

Invited talks

- Keynote Lecture: Transversal Research Priorities - Democracy Studies, University of Zurich (due: 11/2026)

Teaching and Mentoring

Teaching (PG = Postgraduate level; UG = Undergraduate level)

- **University of Oxford, Department of Politics and International Relations** — Oxford, UK
  Text-as-Data Instructor, Oxford Spring School in Advanced Social Research Methods — *Spring 2027*
- **University of Zurich, Department of Political Science** — Zurich, CH
  Course Convenor:
  - Computational Political Science Methods (PG/UG) — *Fall 2025-2026*
  - Political Campaign Strategy (UG) — *Fall 2025-2026*
  - Digital Politics (UG) — *Spring 2025-2026*
- **Yale University, Institution for Social and Policy Studies** — New Haven, USA
  Workshop on Fine-tuning, Evaluating and Employing Large Language Models — *Spring 2024*
- **University of Oxford, Oxford Internet Institute** — Oxford, UK
  Teaching Assistant:
  - Digital Social Research Method: Statistics Core (PG) — *Fall 2022*
  - Digital Era Politics and Government (PG) — *Spring 2022*

Mentoring

- 2 PhD Students, University of Zurich
- 2 BA/MSc students, University of Zurich

Research Experience

- **AuthLib Project; CEU Democracy Institute & EU Horizon 2020** — Oxford, UK
  Research Assistant; Advisors: Prof(s) Stephen Whitefield & Spyros Kosmidis — *2022 - 2023*
  Constructed a research design to collect a large textual dataset of public opinion, train a machine learning classifier for illiberal behaviour, and analyse data.
- **Sciences Po; Centre for European Studies and Comparative Politics** — Remote, Paris, FRA
  Research Assistant; Advisor: Prof Caterina Froio — *2022 - 2023*
  Developed a machine learning classifier to classify protest events based on a large dataset of human-coded newspaper articles from European multilingual sources.
- **University of Oxford** — Oxford, UK
  Research Assistant; Advisor: Prof Spyros Kosmidis — *Spring 2022*
  Applied transfer learning to conduct a sentiment analysis based on roBERTa, and designed and implemented sequence classification based on a pre-labelled corpus of 2,000 political tweets.

  Research Assistant; Advisor: Dr Vicente Valentim — *Spring 2022*
  Built large Twitter posts dataset, applied and validated sentiment analyses for multilingual text.

  Research Assistant; Advisor: Prof Joerg Friedrichs — *Fall 2020*
  Programmed web-scraping tools to build large online electoral datasets. Coded data with pre-trained machine learning classifiers. Analysed data via time-series analyses.
- **University of Exeter** — Exeter, UK
  Research Assistant; Advisor: Prof Clare Saunders — *2018 - 2019*
  Produced literature review on affective polarisation. Coded and analysed interview transcripts about the 2015 UK Badger Culling policy, involving governmental actors, police, stakeholders and citizens.

Professional Experience

- **UK Labour Party** — Remote, London, UK
  Research Associate — *2024 - 2025*
  Collaborated with Labour's Data Science and Communication teams, using machine learning, natural language processing, and causal inference methods.
- **Italian Democratic Party - Piave Digital Agency** — Remote, Bologna, IT
  Research Associate — *2022 - 2023*
  Collected and analysed public opinion data on Stefano Bonaccini (President of Emilia Romagna Regional Council) during the Democratic Party's 2023 leadership elections.

Academic Service

- Admissions committee member, Master in Comparative and International Studies (MACIS), University of Zurich and ETH Zurich. *2026 - Present*
- Working Group Member, "AI in Teaching" Task Force, University of Zurich *2025 - Present*
- Organised a seminar featuring Prof. Pablo Barberá (Meta; University of Southern California) on *Using Social Media Data for Social Science Research* at the Department of Politics, University of Oxford. *Spring 2023*
- Referee for: *European Journal of Political Research; Political Behaviour; Legislative Studies Quarterly; Political Research Quarterly; PLOS One; Theory & Society; International Journal of Comparative Sociology; Minds & Machines; Journal of Information Technology & Politics.*

Grants and Awards

External

- Elinor Ostrom Prize, Italian Political Science Association (with Clemente, A.), EUR 500 *2025*
- ESRC Advanced Quantitative Scholarship (Tuition fees and stipend), approx. GBP 200,000 *2021 - 2025*
- ESRC and Nuffield College Travel Grants, approx. GBP 10,000 *2021-2025*
- ESRC Overseas Institutional Visit Fund, GBP 4,000 *Spring 2024*

Internal

- IPZ Research Grant, University of Zurich, CHF 10,000 *2026*
- Inequality Research Fund, University of Zurich (with Clemente, A.), CHF 6,050 *2025*
- Nuffield College - Research Grant, approx. GBP 6,000 *Spring 2025*
- Nuffield College - Yale Exchange Programme, approx. GBP 18,000 *Spring 2024*
- Nuffield College DPhil Scholarship (College fees) *2021 - 2025*
- Victor Wiseman Prize, University of Exeter - Best grade overall and dissertation *2019*

Languages and Skills

- **Languages**: Italian (native), English (bilingual), French and Spanish (professional proficiency), German (beginner)
- **Coding**: Python, R, SQL, SPSS, PHP, HTML, CSS
- **Key libraries**: PyTorch, TensorFlow, scikit, Keras, NLTK, NetworkX, tidyverse, ggplot, dplyr, tidyr
- **Platforms**: Anaconda, VSCode, RStudio, Docker, AWS, Git/GitHub, Google Console & Workspace
- **Publishing**: Git/GitHub, Rmarkdown, Jupyter Notebooks, LaTeX, DataVerse

References

- Prof Fabrizio Gilardi, Political Science Department, University of Zurich: gilardi@ipz.uzh.ch.
- Prof Caterina Froio, Centre for European Studies and Comparative Politics, Sciences Po: caterina.froio@sciencespo.fr.
- Prof Spyros Kosmidis, Department of Politics, University of Oxford: spyros.kosmidis@politics.ox.ac.uk.
- Prof Ralph Schroeder, Oxford Internet Institute, University of Oxford: ralph.schroeder@oii.ox.ac.uk.